PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 13 - Modern Conflict: Civil Wars, Terrorism, and Current Events

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- Monday: **why war happens** — selection bias, the bargaining logic, and the five paths to war
- Today: how conflict has **evolved** in the modern era
  - From interstate war to civil war and terrorism
  - What is genuinely new about contemporary conflict?
- Last part of class: **discussion on the US/Israel action against Iran**

Today's Schedule

- Civil Wars in International Politics
- Terrorism: Definition and Logic
- Current Events Activity: US/Israel & Iran

Civil Wars in International Politics

What are Civil Wars?

The Dominant Form of Armed Conflict

- The dominant form of armed conflict since 1945 is **not** interstate war — it is civil war
- Civil wars: conflicts between a government and at least one organized armed group **within a state**
- Does the framework we discussed Monday (deadweight losses, five causes) still apply within states, or do we need a different theory?

Recall: The Five Causes of War

Quick check — can you name all five?

1. **Unchecked interests** — leaders bear no personal cost
2. **Intangible incentives** — spiritual, ideological, or honor-based rewards
3. **Uncertainty** — neither side knows the other's true strength
4. **Commitment problems** — neither side can credibly commit to a future agreement
5. **Misperceptions** — one or both sides held systematically wrong beliefs

Commitment Problems at the Heart of Civil Wars

- Civil wars are fundamentally driven by **commitment problems**
  - The state cannot credibly promise to share power with rebels after they disarm
  - Rebels know this — so they refuse to disarm
- South Sudan: the president promised political inclusion, but centralized presidential power made the promise **not credible** — rival elites rebelled rather than disarm
  - The international community focused on dialogue and development aid — but missed the **underlying commitment problem**: who controls the oil revenues and the state apparatus?

Civil Wars Have Always Mattered

- Romans intervened in the civil war between Cleopatra and Ptolemy XIII to assert control over Egypt
- France intervened in the American Revolution to weaken Britain
- Great powers have **always** used civil wars to weaken rivals, open intervention opportunities, or lock in favorable deals
- What does this pattern tell us about the relationship between civil war and the international system?

What Is New About Civil Wars Today?

- Today's civil wars are distinctive in important ways:
  1. They are **espousing extreme ideologies**
  2. They are **pursuing transnational goals** — conflicts that refuse to respect state borders
- Which of these do you think is harder to explain with the theories we have?

Why Are These Things Happening?

- *"The internet has given even the smallest rebel groups the same access to large audiences as the governments they are seeking to defeat"*
- Transnational appeals allow groups to recruit **globally** rather than relying on a local support base
- You don't need to win in one country — you can **sustain yourself** from diaspora, sympathizers, foreign donors
- Does social media explain radicalization, or just accelerate a pre-existing process?

Consequences of Transnational Conflict

- Civil wars are going to **last longer**, be **harder to resolve**, and be **worse for civilians**
- Conflict is no longer **geographically contained**
    - Lone-actor attacks in countries with no direct stake in the original conflict
- More rebel groups; groups spread further; more brutal tactics (less dependent on civilian support)
- Harder to negotiate — you cannot address the underlying political grievance when the goal is global transformation

Terrorism: Definition and Logic

What Is Terrorism?

Turn to the person next to you: is each of the following an act of terrorism? Yes, no, or unsure? (1 minute)

1. Blowing up a government building and the civilians inside it
2. Blowing up a barracks full of soldiers
3. Kidnapping your political opponents and then killing them
4. Imposing an economic boycott on a country that causes civilians to die from lack of food or medicine
5. Bombing a city that has many civilians but few, if any, soldiers or military targets

Defining Terrorism: Why It Is Hard

- Terrorism is notoriously difficult to define — and **defining it is always deeply political**
- The label "terrorism" has rhetorical power that is used as a political weapon
  - It is deeply embedded with structures of racism and bigotry
- *"One man's terrorist is another man's freedom fighter"*
- Core elements of a consensus scholarly definition:
  - **Use or threat of violence** against noncombatants
  - **For political goals**
  - **Intent to create fear** beyond the immediate victims

Who Becomes a Terrorist?

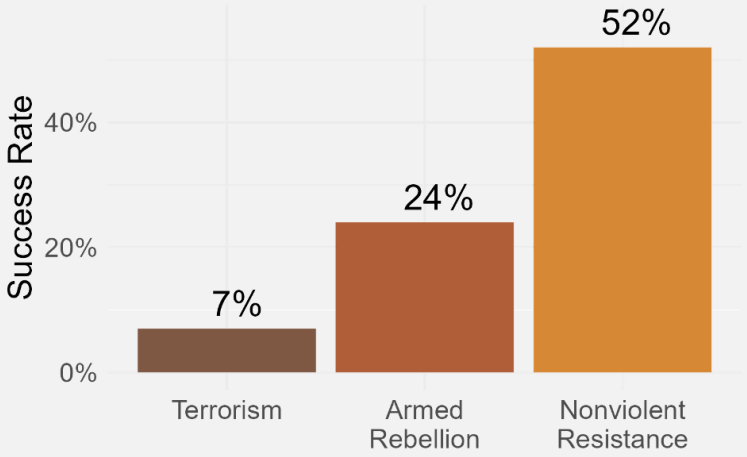
- Remember the problem of **selection bias** — there is no single consistent demographic profile
- The NYPD's post-9/11 radicalization guide flagged: inability to grow potted plants, spending time in "hookah bars, butcher shops, and bookstores"
    - This approach was analytically useless and discriminatory, no clear profile
- "A quest for identity and greater significance in the world together with empathy for those who are suffering." from Rupert Brown
- Does this surprise you? Does it change how you think about counter-terrorism?

Why do terrorist groups engage in terrorism?

Do they do it because it works?

Terrorism does sometimes succeed

But much less frequently than the alternatives



Data from Abrahms 2006, Chenoweth and Stephan 2011

If terrorism doesn’t work most of the time, why do groups keep using it?

Terrorism as a Communicative Act

- Terrorism is designed to **communicate**, not to win militarily
- Three audiences:
  1. **Civilians**: undermine their sense of safety and security
  2. **The state**: provoke an extreme response that undermines the government's legitimacy
  3. **Potential supporters**: signal commitment and ideological intensity to attract members
- More than a decade after Osama bin Laden's death, most Americans could identify his photo; far fewer could identify the President of Mexico or Prime Minister of Canada

How Do States Fight Terrorism?

- **Resolve the underlying issue through politics**: the Good Friday Agreement and the end of the IRA's campaign in Northern Ireland
- **Make attacks harder to carry out (policing)**: TSA, surveillance, border security — reduces opportunities but does not address root causes
- **Use military force**: kill or capture members — can degrade capacity but risks creating martyrs and new recruits
- What are the tradeoffs between these approaches? Which do you think is most effective?

Current Events Activity: US/Israel & Iran

Setting the Stage - Iran - US War???

Who volunteered to present? Let's start with a brief overview of what you found

(Volunteer presentation — 5 minutes, no slides required)

Discussion Questions: What States Say vs. What They Mean

As a class, let's work through these:

1. What were the **stated justifications** from each actor? What do you think the **real strategic goals** were?
2. Where do stated justifications **align** with strategic interests? Where do they **diverge**?
3. What does **Iran say**? What do regional actors (Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Russia, China) say — and what do their positions tell us about their own interests?
4. If you had to use the tools/frameworks from this class, how would you frame the conflict?

Discussion Questions: Norms and the International Order

Let's think about the bigger picture:

1. Which norms are being **contested** here: sovereignty, non-intervention, the norm against first use of force?
2. Does this case involve **territorial conquest**, or is it a different kind of norm violation? How does it compare to the Russia-Ukraine case we discussed Monday?
3. Does the **international community's response** matter? What happens if it doesn't?
4. What **precedent** does this action set for the future?

Summary

- Civil wars are not structurally different from interstate wars — commitment problems are central to both
- What is new today: **transnational ideology and global recruitment**, enabled by social media
- Terrorism is a **communicative strategy**, not a military one — and it rarely achieves political goals
- The Iran case shows that even real-world events can be analyzed with our theoretical tools
- **Coming up next week**: Midterm Review (Monday) and Midterm Exam (Wednesday, March 11) — bring questions!

Questions?